school building. We got down from the car and stood in front of the gate.

c. Who were Aditya's ancestors?

d. How was the landscape through which they travelled.

e. What did Aditya visit?

I asked Aditya whether everything was still the same. He replied that everything had changed.

'Our school used to be one-storeyed, and a new building has come up, which wasn't there.'

'Were you not a good student?' I asked.

'Yes, but my position was always second,' he replied. We decided to go and have tea at Nagen uncle's tea shop, which stood next to a grocery shop and opposite a temple dedicated to Lord Shiva. Soon, we caught sight of 'Nagen's Tea Cabin' written on a signboard over the shop.

The owner of the tea shop, now over sixty, a little rustic in appearance, with his white neatly-combed hair and clean look, was the same as before. He was wearing a dhoti and a blue striped shirt that could be seen from under a green shawl.

Not recognising Aditya, he asked us where we had come from.

'Deodarganj,' Aditya replied. 'We are on our way to Kolkata.'

A little surprised, Nagen uncle asked why we were there.

'To have tea at your shop, ' said Aditya. 'Certainly, besides tea, I have biscuits and savouries.'



'Give us two *nankhatai* each.'.

f. Where was Nagen uncle's shop?

g. Besides tea, what did Nagen uncle have in his shop?

We sat on two tin chairs. There was only one other customer sitting at a corner table, neither eating nor drinking tea, but sitting with his head bent, as though he were sleeping.

Addressing him as Mr Sanyal, Nagen uncle reminded him to go home, as it was already 4 p.m. Other customers would soon be coming. Addressing us he said, with a wink in his eye, 'A little hard of hearing. Cannot see well either. But has no money to buy spectacles.'

From his reaction to this speech, I began to wonder whether Mr Sanyal was not a little crazy as well, because suddenly he stood up, stretched himself and, raising his lean right arm, and with eyes dilated, began to recite a poem by Tagore – Panraksha ('Keeping of a Promise'). Having recited the poem, he left the place, making the gesture of Namaste with his hands, to nobody in particular.

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